

RECENT INCIDENTS IN PUNJAB HAVE RAISED FEARS OF A RETURN TO TERRORISM.

LUDHIANA | Terror Tremor

A shootout at the Ludhiana railway station has raised questions on terrorism sticking its head out in Punjab yet again. Though top police officials differ in their assessment with very few suspecting regrouping of terrorists, many feel that recent indications are disturbing. Babbar Khalsa militant Balbir Singh Bhootna was arrested in the shootout when he tried to escape after firing at the cops, leaving a vendor dead. This was the third incident in recent days after the killings of Rulda Singh of the Rashtriya Sikh Sangat and Lily Kumar, a Dera Sacha Sauda follower. Both incidents are being linked to Punjab militants. Bhootna's interrogations led the police to arrest another activist Daljit Singh Bittu and it has come out that funds from abroad are trickling in to lend an impetus to the "campaign" in the state.

by Arvind Chhabra



BHOOTNA (SECOND FROM RIGHT)

PATNA | Towering Targets

Blowing up mobile phone towers seem to be the new weapon of destruction for Maoists. Last week, the rebels blasted three towers in Bihar and two in Jharkhand during their 48-hour bandh. They are said to be attacking telecom towers to prevent the police eavesdropping on their conversations, and to neutralise police informers. The ultras have destroyed nearly 70 such installations during the last three years. With Chhattisgarh topping the tally, such attacks have also been recorded in Jharkhand, Andhra Pradesh and Orissa.

by Amitabh Srivastava

FACING FLAK OVER THE STATUE CONTROVERSY, MAYAWATI GOES IN FOR AN IMAGE CHANGE.

LUCKNOW | Maya's Makeover



After receiving flak from the Congress for going on a statue- and park-building spree, Chief Minister Mayawati is now looking for an image makeover. In an apparent damage control exercise, she said that she will not celebrate her birthday as aarthik sahyog diwas (financial aid day) and that no one would have to collect money from government officials as in the past. In December 2008, Manoj Gupta, an executive engineer in the PWD was allegedly killed by BSP MLA Shekhar Tiwari for not paying up for aarthik sahyog diwas. There were also a number of complaints that BSP workers were extorting money from the public for her birthday. Further, in a move to consolidate her hold in the party, Mayawati also elected herself as BSP chief for another three years at a party meeting on August 29.

by Subhash Mishra

DELHI | Lucky Oye

Recently, when the Foreign Ministry decided to replace its fleet of ambassador cars with the SX4 for the use of its ministers, it sparked a war for lucky numbers. While External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna settled for 1111, the tussle for number 2222 was between Minister of State Shashi Tharoor and his counterpart Preneet Kaur, who felt that since she is senior, she should get the number. Finally, Tharoor was allotted 2206 as his twins were born in June. by Saurabh Shukla